

CORE FORMULA

Context in one line -> specific action -> specific object -> specific output -> boundary or opt-out. -> Full: "Because [context], could you [action] [object] and send me [output] by [time]? No problem if that is not feasible." -> Minimum: "Could you [action] [object] and tell me [output]?" -> Pressure-safe: "Would it be reasonable to ask you to [action] [object] by [time]? If not, I can adjust the ask."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask for one specific action on one specific object, with one clear output.

BEST FOR

- Asking for feedback, a review, a decision or an approval
- Requesting help, an introduction or the right owner for something
- Booking meeting time with a clear purpose
- Digital replies where a yes/no or one detail is all you need
- Stakeholder or client input on a specific point
- Small behaviour changes stated plainly
- Any moment where 'can you help?' would create too much interpretation work

PHRASE BANK

Quick / one-liners · Short openers and starter asks

- "Could you answer just this part?"
- "Could you reply with a yes or no?"
- "Which of these two dates works better?"
- "Could you point me to the right owner?"
- "One quick thing: which option do you prefer?"
- "Could you send me the one number I'm missing?"
- "Just the headline is fine for now."
- "Could you confirm the time? Nothing else needed."

Digital / text · Message-length asks with a clear reply path

- "Could you reply with yes/no on option B by 3 pm? Detail can wait."
- "Could you reply with the best contact name? No intro needed yet."
- "Reply with the one blocker and I'll handle the rest."
- "A thumbs up or down is enough here."
- "Could you drop me the file name, not the whole folder?"
- "Which line do I change? Just point to it."

Close & personal · Emotionally aware specificity

- "Could you tell me what you need from me tonight: listening, problem-solving or space?"
- "Could you tell me whether you want advice, help with logistics or just listening?"
- "Would it help if I took one thing off your plate? Tell me which."
- "I don't need the whole story, just the part that's worrying you most."
- "Could you let me know one way I can actually help this week?"
- "No rush, but could you tell me which day suits you?"
- "Tell me the single thing that would make tomorrow easier."

Work & meetings · Review, decision and status asks

- "Could you review the two highlighted risks and tell me whether either blocks approval?"
- "Could we spend ten minutes deciding the next owner and the due date?"
- "Could you sanity-check the numbers in rows 12 to 20 only?"
- "Could you confirm whether the blocker is budget, timing or scope?"
- "Could you send me the three blockers by noon, with an owner for each?"
- "Could you mark the one slide where the story breaks, rather than reworking the deck?"
- "Could you tell me the biggest risk you see in option A, in one or two lines?"

Naming the exact ask · Action plus output, said plainly

- "Could you decide whether the launch date moves or stays?"
- "Could you review the pricing section and send me the one objection a client is most likely to raise?"
- "Could you choose option A or B, whichever you can live with?"
- "What I need is a decision, not a full review."
- "Could you mark the one paragraph that feels least clear?"
- "Could you introduce me to the person who owns this?"
- "Could you tell me the single thing that would change your mind?"

Softening & opt-out · Boundary-safe, autonomy-preserving asks

- "No problem if the answer is no; I mainly wanted to make the ask clear."
- "Would it be reasonable to ask for a five-minute read of the first page only?"
- "If that timing doesn't work, just tell me what does."
- "If this isn't realistic, I can ask someone else."
- "Only if you have the capacity; otherwise ignore this."
- "I'd rather you were honest than say yes and resent it."
- "Say the word and I'll take this off your list."

Pressure & conflict · Decisions under strain

- "The specific decision I need is whether we pause, continue or escalate by noon."
- "Could you tell me the one part of the proposal you object to most?"
- "Bottom line: I need a yes or no on this by three."
- "Could you tell me the one risk that would make you stop the launch?"
- "I want to respond to the right thing, so tell me your main objection."
- "If we can only fix one thing before Friday, which should it be?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Can you help me with this?

Better: Can you review this draft?

Best: Could you review the two highlighted paragraphs and tell me whether the tone is too direct by Thursday afternoon? No line edits needed.

2. Weak: What do you think?

Better: What do you think of option A?

Best: Could you tell me the biggest risk you see in option A, in one or two bullets?

3. Weak: Can we talk?

Better: Can we talk about the project?

Best: Could we take ten minutes today to decide whether the launch date moves or stays?

DECISION TREE

If You are about to make a request

If it isn't really a request, don't force this. Just talk.

If They are emotionally activated

Listen, validate or repair before asking for anything.

"Before I ask anything, how are you doing with all this?"

If You can't name the exact action

Clarify your own need first; don't outsource the thinking to them.

"Give me a second to work out what I'm actually asking."

If You can name the action, object and output

State them in one clean sentence.

"Could you review the pricing section and send me the one likely objection?"

If The ask is large or costly

Shrink it or name the full size honestly, and add an opt-out.

"This is a bigger ask than it sounds. No problem if it's a no."

If The ask landed as pressure

Recover by narrowing, contextualising or releasing pressure.

"I made that too broad. The specific ask is just this one thing."

SCENARIOS

Work feedback

Ask for one marked spot, not a rewrite. — "Could you mark the one slide where the story breaks, rather than rewriting the deck?"

Manager to direct report

Name the output, the count and the time box, then offer a fallback time. — "Could you send me the three blockers by noon, with an owner for each? If noon is unrealistic, tell me the earliest time."

Peer request

Narrow the scope to the exact rows or section. — "Could you sanity-check the numbers in rows 12 to 20 only?"

Client or stakeholder

Turn a vague blocker into a single either/or question. — "Could you confirm whether the approval blocker is budget, timing or scope?"

Family or close relationship

Ask which kind of support they want before giving it. — "Could you tell me whether you want advice, help with logistics or just listening?"

High-status or guarded person

Offer the specific version and the full-context version, and let them choose. — "Would it help if I sent one specific decision for your review, or would you prefer the full context first?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The other person is upset and needs to feel heard before anything is asked of them
- The relationship needs empathy or repair before action
- The real ask is large and must be named honestly rather than shrunk to sound easy
- You are not yet sure what you actually need
- The request would be unfair even if it were phrased perfectly clearly
- Naming one option now would prematurely close off better ones
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority over careful phrasing

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the vague asks

List five requests you made recently that started with 'help', 'thoughts', 'feedback', 'support' or 'can we talk?'. Just collect them; don't fix them yet.

Day 2 — Break one down

Take one vague ask and write its four parts separately: the action verb, the exact object, the output you need, and the boundary or deadline.

Day 3 — Rewrite in one sentence

Turn yesterday's four parts into a single answerable sentence, e.g. 'Could you spend ten minutes on the pricing section and send me the one objection a client is most likely to raise by Friday?'

Day 4 — Add the opt-out

Take three of your rewritten asks and add a clean refusal or renegotiation line to each, such as 'No problem if that's not realistic.'

Day 5 — Find the verb before you send

Before sending any request today, underline the action verb. If there isn't one, rewrite the ask until there is.

Day 6 — Use one live

In a real conversation or message, make one specific ask and watch whether they answer the exact question or ask you what you mean.

Day 7 — Partner pressure-test

Ask a colleague or friend to give you a deliberately vague request. Reply only with 'What action, object, output and boundary?' until their ask is answerable but still respectful, then swap roles.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I actually know what I was asking for?
- Did I name one clear action rather than a vague category of help?
- Did I name the object and the output I needed?
- Did I include timing or a fair boundary where it mattered?
- Did I leave room for no, delay or renegotiation?
- Did the final ask reduce ambiguity without adding pressure?